



A Wittgensteinian Critique of the Truthmaker Maximalism and the Pluralistic Explanation

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Abstract

This paper presents a Wittgensteinian critique of the truthmaker maximalism—which holds that every truth is made true by at least one truthmaker. The argument proceeds in three stages: First, I demonstrate that truthmaker maximalism’s motivations are fundamentally unmotivated, sharing the same philosophical vulnerabilities that Wittgenstein identified in Augustine’s picture of language. Second, I argue that Wittgenstein’s conception of proposition as a family resemblance concept necessitates a pluralistic view of explanation, suggesting that truthmakers constitute just one type of explanans among many. Third, within this pluralistic framework, I address the challenge of negative truths for the truthmaker maximalism.

Keywords Truthmaker maximalism · Wittgenstein · Family resemblance · Pluralistic explanations

1 Introduction

The idea of truthmakers, while prominently associated with contemporary philosophy, traces its origins back to Aristotle. Aristotle observed:

[I]f there is a man, the statement whereby we say that there is a man is true, and reciprocally—since if the statement whereby we say that there is a man is true, there is a man. And whereas the true statement is in no way the cause of the actual thing’s existence, the actual thing does seem in some way the cause of the statement’s being true: it is because the actual thing exists or does not that the statement is called true or false.¹

¹ See Aristotle (1984, p.22).

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This Aristotle's insight deals with contingent existentials (e.g., $\langle \text{there is a man} \rangle$),² but does not explicitly endorse the truthmaker maximalism—the claim that every truth is true in virtue of at least one truthmaker. Truthmakers, in contemporary debates, are understood as the “ontological grounds” of truths.³ A central issue is whether maximalism, the extension of truthmaker theory to all truths, is adequately motivated.⁴

Aristotle clearly emphasised the asymmetry between truthbearers (e.g., propositions) and truthmakers; specifically, it is the truthmaker that renders the truthbearer true, but not that the truthbearer brings about the existence of the truthmaker. This thought has been inherited by contemporary truthmaker theorists. It is important to note that Aristotle used the term “cause” in a sense distinct from its modern interpretation.⁵ Today, we often employ the terms “makes” and “brings about” in a noncausal sense. As Armstrong explains, “The best formulation of what this making is seems to be given by the phrase ‘in virtue of’. It is in virtue of that independent reality that the proposition is true. What makes the proposition a truth is how it stands to this reality.”⁶ For this reason, the truthmaker theory serves as a guide to ontology, identifying truthmakers as the ontological commitments of truthbearers.

Another question that Aristotle did not raise is what exactly the relationship between the truthmaker and the truthbearer is. In other words, how can we cash out the phrase “in virtue of”? Armstrong proposed the cross-categorical truthmaking necessitarianism, according to which the truth of a truthbearer is necessitated by its truthmaker. Assuming that truths are true propositions,⁷ the truthmaking necessitarians assert that for any true proposition p and any entity x , if x is p 's truthmaker, then necessarily the mere existence of x is sufficient for p 's being true. The combination of truthmaker maximalism and truthmaking necessitarianism forms what is often referred to as the orthodox truthmaker theory (OTT).

In addition to necessitation, Lowe introduced an explanatory dimension to the truthmaking relation. He wrote, “When we say that a true proposition needs to be ‘made’ true, we mean that it has to be true ‘in virtue of’ something, where ‘in virtue of’ expresses what I would call a relationship of metaphysical explanation. In other words, a true proposition must have truth conferred upon it in some way which

² I shall follow the conventional use of “ $\langle \rangle$ ” to stand for “the proposition that”.

³ See Armstrong (1991, p.190). Truthmaker theorists tacitly admit that truthmakers are entities that exist in reality. I follow this mainstream use of the term “truthmakers”, if I do not particularly emphasize it otherwise.

⁴ The camp of truthmaker maximalism includes Armstrong (1997, 2004), Cameron (2005, 2008), Heil (2003) and others.

⁵ Aristotle's four causes do not seem to cover this usage. Maybe it belongs to the formal cause. But according to Aristotle, the formal cause is the form which is the account of what-it-is-to-be. It is far-fetched to say that truthmakers are the account of what truthbearers are.

⁶ Armstrong (2004, p.5).

⁷ Choosing propositions as truthbearers is just for convenience. My arguments do not depend on this choice. Naturalists may prefer other truthbearers to propositions. But we can still have a naturalistic view on propositions. See Armstrong (2004, p.12). He treated propositions as the intentional objects of beliefs and thoughts, or the intentional objects of statements. They are abstract not because of belonging to any other worlds like Platonist numbers, but because they are contents and meanings as types.

explains how it gets to be true.”⁸ This explanatory aspect of truthmaking is a central focus of my paper.

Opponents of the truthmaker maximalism generally endorse a weaker version of the theory, maintaining that while some truths require truthmakers, not all do. For instance, weak truthmaker theorists argue that only certain truths have truthmakers.⁹ This paper argues against the truthmaker maximalism and adopts a very restricted weak truthmaker view, informed by a pluralistic explanatory perspective. In this pluralistic view, truth explanations are multifaceted and depend on the nature of the truth in question. Some truths, particularly contingent ones, are explained through features of reality, while others may rely on entirely different explanans. This perspective diverges from OTT by rejecting its assumption of universal applicability. Instead, it aligns with Wittgenstein’s critique of the uniformity of explanation, rooted in his concept of family resemblance. Hence, my critique of OTT is Wittgensteinian.

The paper unfolds as follows: Sect. 2 critiques the motivations behind the Maximalism, linking its assumptions to Augustine’s problematic language picture. Section 3 argues that Wittgenstein’s family resemblance concept underpins a pluralistic explanatory framework.¹⁰ Section 4 explores this framework in relation to negative truths, presenting a viable alternative to the Maximalism.

2 The Motivation of Truthmaker Maximalism

When we encounter a philosophical theory, it is natural to enquire into the motivation behind it. Armstrong thought that the truthmaker theory is conducive to arguing against Millian phenomenalism and Rylean behaviourism. John Bigelow argued that it is necessary to insist on truthmaker theory to avoid idealism.¹¹ However, even accepting these motivations, it is insufficient to motivate the truthmaker maximalism. The leap from “some truths have truthmakers” to “all truths have truthmakers” encounters immediate difficulties when we consider propositions beyond ordinary affirmative ones. Take, for instance, the negative proposition <There are no unicorns>, or the counterfactual <If Zidane had not head-butted Materazzi, France might have won the 2006 World Cup>. It is not clear what their truthmaker is because there seems to be no states of affairs to make them true. Other problematic cases emerge with general propositions, and mathematical propositions, among others.

How do we determine truth-values for such propositions? Armstrong and other maximalists address these challenges not by restricting their theory, but by expanding their ontology. Their aim encompasses all truth-apt propositions, regardless of their nature. The underlying motivation for this ambition stems from the theoretical

⁸ Lowe (2006, p.193).

⁹ The camp of weak truthmaker theory includes Lewis (1992), Mellor (2003), Simons (2005) and others. They disagree on what kind of truths do not have truthmakers.

¹⁰ I shall argue below that what we really need are explanations for truths. Truthmakers are only one type of explanans. But as the discussion is always around truthmaker theory, so sometimes I use “truthmaker” to mean explanans.

¹¹ See Armstrong (2004, p.1); Bigelow (1988, p.123); Also cf. David Liggins (2005).

pursuit of elegance and unification. Yet, surveying the truthmaker literature reveals a troublingly optimistic phenomenon: few philosophers critically examine the motivation for truthmaker theory, seemingly accepting it as granted. More concerning, regarding truthmaker maximalism, there appears to be no substantive arguments supporting it. Its primary motivation rests on brute intuition and theoretical ambition. As Armstrong candidly acknowledges, he lacks a direct argument for this expansion:

I do not have any direct argument [for maximalism]. My hope is that philosophers of realist inclinations will be immediately attracted to the idea that a truth, any truth, should depend for its truth for something ‘outside’ it, in virtue of which it is true.¹²

While Armstrong attempted to provide truthmakers for various categories of truths, I contend that his admirable effort went astray. This aspiration for unification leads maximalists into a trap identical to that found in Augustine’s picture of language: both erroneously take what is “appropriate” for a specific “narrowly circumscribed region” and attempt to apply it to “the whole of what you were claiming to describe”.¹³

Wittgenstein opens his discussion in the *Philosophical Investigations* with an assessment of Augustine’s description of learning language: “the words in language name objects—sentences are combinations of such names...Every word has a meaning. This meaning is correlated with the word. It is the object for which the word stands.” In this picture, the essential function of words is naming objects, creating the impression that all words are names. Wittgenstein argues that someone holding this view, “is, I believe, thinking primarily of nouns like ‘table’, ‘chair’, ‘bread’ and of people’s names”.¹⁴ These names become the paradigm of words in language, and other words are presumed to function in the same way as these paradigmatic words.

Similarly, truthmaker maximalists follow Augustine’s paradigmatic approach: they begin with contingently affirmative propositions such as <Mount Everest exists> and <the table is yellow>. These propositions are true in virtue of the object or fact they describe, or in the truthmaker terminology, they are made true by some entities.¹⁵ Such propositions then serve as paradigmatic cases, leading the truthmaker theorists to assert that other propositions, including negative propositions, counterfactuals, and modal propositions and so on, must likewise be made true by some entities.

The apparent uniformity of propositions is illusory; the difference runs deeper. Although our ordinary languages employ terms like “mathematical facts,” “ethical facts” and so forth, beyond their similarity of grammatical structure, their contents remain quite different. This fundamental difference in content necessitates different explanations for their being true or false. A critic might object that insisting on this difference merely presupposes what is to be proven. However, this distinction is not a theoretical imposition but a manifest feature of linguistic practice. If we follow Wittgenstein’s maxim to “look” rather than “think”, the difference becomes evident in our criteria for verification. For instance, to explain the truth of the proposition <my desk

¹² Armstrong (2004, p. 7).

¹³ Wittgenstein (2010, § 3).

¹⁴ Ibid.

¹⁵ Many truthmaker theorists believe that facts or states of affairs as entities constitutes what there is. In Sect. 3, I shall argue against this view.

is square>, one must perform an observation of the physical world; the “truthmaker” is discovered through sensory experience. In contrast, explaining the truth of a mathematical proposition like $\langle 2+2=4 \rangle$ involves no such observation of the world, but rather the construction of a proof. And explaining the truth of a counterfactual regrading historical truth may require a complex web of historical and economic inferences, but not the identification of a “counterfactual entity”.

Here, am I conflating the explanation of a truth (an epistemological matter) with what makes it true (an ontological matter)? One might argue that while we verify mathematical truths via proofs and empirical truths via observation, the underlying metaphysical relation—that of being “made true” by a fact—remains uniform. However, this objection presupposes a gap between grammar and reality that Wittgenstein explicitly rejects. To ask “what makes p true?” is precisely to ask for the explanation of p within its language game. Moreover, some truthmaker theorists have acknowledged the explanatory dimension. For instance, McFetridge asserted, “For every sentence which is true there must be some explanation of why it is true.”¹⁶ Similarly Bigelow maintained, “[Truthmakers] are entities whose entire *raison d'être* is to explain what makes a linguistic item true.”¹⁷ Thus the accusation of the conflation of the explanation of a truth with what makes it true is invalid.

In sum, the truthmaker maximalism emerges as the consequence of insisting on Augustine’s picture of language at the sentential level. Were Augustine’s picture correct, it would follow that sentences, as combinations of names, must stand for corresponding combinations of objects represented by their constituent names. This would seem to validate the claim that every truth has at least one truthmaker, namely the combinations of objects that the proposition’s components stand for. This picture aligns with Armstrong’s assertion that “The world is a world of states of affairs.”¹⁸ These states of affairs, as combinations of objects, necessarily involve the objects corresponding to the names in sentences.

Having rejected the view that naming constitutes the essential function of words, we must consequently abandon the idea that assertions essentially stand for facts or states of affairs. What alternative remains? Given our earlier argument that the meaning of a word is its use, it follows that the nature of a proposition cannot be understood apart from the practice in which it is employed. Here, one might object that context sensitivity applies only to sentences, whereas the propositions they express possess determinate truth conditions.¹⁹ However, this objection misses the deeper Wittgenstein’s point: the context of use does not merely fix reference (i.e., determining which proposition is expressed); it reveals the logical type of the proposition. When we examine these logical types, we see that truth functions differently across different language games. For instance, the truth of the positive existential $\langle \text{there is a mountain called Everest} \rangle$ depends on an external reality, whereas the truth of a mathematical proposition depends entirely on the internal rules of symbol manipulation. Thus, the error of maximalism is not only neglecting the context of sentences, but

¹⁶ McFetridge (1990, p.42); quoted from Liggins (2005, p.112).

¹⁷ Bigelow (1988, p.121).

¹⁸ See Armstrong (1993, p.429–440). This idea was also held by Wittgenstein in *The Tractatus*.

¹⁹ I am grateful to one reviewer who raises this point.

forcing these fundamentally diverse logical functions into a single, uniform model of describing a state of affairs.

3 Family Resemblance and Pluralistic Explanations

I have argued that our fundamental need lies in explanations to rationalise our beliefs or judgments. Through various examples, I have demonstrated that different kinds of propositions require different types of explanations. While I do not deny that truth-makers constitute one kind of explanation, my central thesis is that explanations are pluralistic. This plurality emerges from the fact that the concept of proposition exhibits family resemblance. Various kinds of proposition form a family, yet they do not share a common feature. Instead, they resemble one another in different ways. As Wittgenstein articulated, “the various resemblances between members of a family... overlap and criss-cross in the same way.”²⁰

The relationship between family resemblance and pluralistic explanations can be articulated as follows: If the concept of proposition lacks essential characteristics, then maintaining a uniform explanans of their truth becomes problematic. Given that truths are heterogeneous, we should correspondingly seek heterogeneous explanans. Upon examination of various kinds of truths, it becomes evident that different kinds of truth are true in virtue of different types of reason. As roughly outlined previously, pluralistic explanations are not merely possible but compelling.

At this point, a maximalist might object that the heterogeneity of propositions and their explanations is entirely compatible with truthmaker maximalism. They might argue that my conclusion does not follow, because one could simply concede that radically different truths require radically different *truthmakers*. However, this objection fundamentally assumes that all explanations of truth must ultimately be ontological (i.e., entity-based). As my pluralistic framework demonstrates, the heterogeneity of propositions reveals that ‘making true’ implies entirely different activities in different domains. For formal truths, such as mathematical propositions, the explanans is internal to the system, and ‘in virtue of’ designates a relation of deductive entailment, not ontological grounding. Because the explanation for a proposition like $<2 + 2 = 4>$ involves the construction of a proof rather than an observation of the world, the maximalist cannot simply posit a different *kind* of truthmaker. Asking for an ontological entity to make such a proposition true fundamentally misunderstands the grammar of mathematical proof. Therefore, the rejection of maximalism is not arbitrary; it is a direct consequence of recognizing that for certain propositions, the requirement for an ontological entity—a truthmaker—is entirely inapplicable. As I will detail more comprehensively in the subsequent sections outlining the Pluralistic Approach (specifically regarding the ‘First Pillar’ of categorical divergence), and in the application of this framework to the problem of negative existentials, these fundamental logical differences preclude any uniform ontological truthmaker.

Opponents might insist that these seemingly heterogeneous explanations for truths are only superficial, arguing that what ultimately makes propositions true are their

²⁰ Wittgenstein (2010, § 67).

truthmakers—the facts or states of affairs that propositions stand for. However, this position necessarily ascribes an essence to the concept of a proposition, namely, that propositions have a general form and uniformly stand for facts or states of affairs. Under this view, propositions are ultimately made true by unified truthmakers. Were this claim justified, it might undermine the possibility of pluralistic explanations. Thus, we must examine this “deep thought” critically. Let us consider three possible objections to the claim that propositions form a family.

The first objection attempts to identify the general form of propositions. A prominent candidate for the general form is “This is how things are.” The objector argues that every proposition, regardless of content, ultimately reduces to this assertion of existence or facthood. However, this attempt to locate a unifying essence relies on conflating a propositional *variable* with a propositional *description*. As Wittgenstein demonstrates, the phrase “This is how things are” does not possess independent descriptive content; it functions merely as a tag or a variable (like the letter *p* in logic) that marks a sentence as asserted. To say that “This is how things are” is the general form of propositions is effectively to say that “The general form of propositions is: it is asserted that *p*.” This is a vacuous definition. It tells us nothing about the *nature* of *p* itself. Similarly, sentences like “such and such is the case,” “this is the situation,” and others function merely as propositional schemata. Therefore, to point to < This is how things are > as the general form of propositions is merely to point to a variable tag (*p*) that we attach to assertions. It does not identify a shared metaphysical feature common to all propositions; it merely identifies their shared capacity to be asserted. Thus, the search for a general form collapses into the trivial observation that all propositions can be plugged into the variable schema.

Worse, this schema creates an illusory uniformity. When we apply “This is how things are” to the mathematical proposition < $2 + 2 = 4$ > and the empirical proposition < The cup is red >, the surface grammar suggests they are the same kind of thing (facts). But the “depth grammar” reveals they are distinct: in the former, “how things are” refers to the internal validity of rules; in the latter, it refers to an external physical state. By elevating a variable schema to the status of an essence, the objector masks the fundamental logical differences between these types of truths. Thus, the general form fails to unify propositions; it merely imposes a uniform *notation* upon a family of diverse practices.

A second objection attempts to characterise propositions by appealing to a purportedly common feature: A proposition is whatever can be true or false. Here, being true and being false serve as the criteria of being a proposition. Wittgenstein rejected this proposal on the grounds that it appears to presuppose our ability to independently grasp the concept of truth and falsehood without first understanding the concept of a proposition. He clarified this mistake through an analogy: while the king in chess is the piece that one can check, this does not entail that we can use the concept of check to determine which piece is the king. Understanding what it is to check a piece presupposes knowledge of what a king is, and vice versa. Similarly, understanding truth and falsehood presupposes knowledge of what a proposition is, and vice versa. Thus, Wittgenstein concluded that “...the use of the words ‘true’ and ‘false’ may be

among the constituent parts of this game; and if so it belongs to our concept ‘proposition’ but does not fit it.”²¹

Moreover, truths (falsities) themselves form a family. This follows naturally for those who accept that propositions form a family, since truths (falsities) are simply true (false) propositions. While the objector might reject this, our earlier analysis demonstrated that different categories of truths exhibit fundamental differences. Consider the diverse truth conditions for claims such as $\langle$ the table is square $\rangle$, $\langle 2 + 2 = 4 \rangle$, and $\langle$ torturing children is morally wrong $\rangle$. The reasons for their being true are fundamentally different, with no common thread uniting them. This further supports the contention that truths (falsities) also form a family.

A sophisticated objector might challenge this conclusion by pointing to contemporary deflationary accounts, such as Paul Horwich’s Minimalism.²² The objector might argue that we can provide a reductive definition of propositions as “that which is truth-apt,” provided we adopt a minimalist theory where the concept of truth is fully exhausted by the equivalence schema ($\langle p \rangle$ is true iff p). Under this view, the essence of a proposition is simply its ability to feature in this schema.

However, appealing to Horwich to save the truthmaker maximalism is a self-defeating strategy. Horwich’s minimalism is expressly designed to deny that truth is a substantive property with an underlying metaphysical nature (such as “correspondence with reality”). If the “common feature” of all propositions is merely their deflationary truth-aptness, then this shared property is metaphysically thin. It implies only that propositions play a specific role in our logical economy, not that they all stand in a uniform relation to ontological items. Ironically, the objector’s appeal to Horwich supports my family resemblance thesis rather than the maximalist’s: it suggests that propositions are unified only by a superficial logical function, not by a shared metaphysical constitution that would demand a uniform truthmaker. If truth is minimal, then the grounds for truth can be plural—ranging from physical existence (for empirical claims) to proof-validity (for mathematical claims)—without contradiction. The demand for a single type of truthmaker (like a state of affairs) collapses because the property it is meant to explain (truth) has been revealed as non-substantive.

A third objection proposes that a proposition must at minimum be composed of a subject and a verb. However, interrogative sentences and exclamatory sentences also share this composition, as do some performative acts (e.g., “I name this baby Donald Trump”)²³ Are these propositions? Clearly not, as they are neither true nor false nor do they state how things are. The objector might then confine their claim to assertions—arguing that only assertions composed of at least a subject and a verb are propositions. Yet here again, the chess analogy proves instructive: Haven’t we already understood the concept of a proposition when we understand the concept of an assertion, and vice versa?

²¹ Wittgenstein (2010, § 136).

²² Thanks to one review for raising this objection drawing from Horwich’s minimalism about truth. For Horwich’s view, see Horwich (1999, 2010).

²³ Thanks to Hanoch Ben-Yami for reminding me of the counterexample. He also mentioned that in some language (e.g. Hebrew), a subject term followed by an adjective can be a proposition: $\langle$ John tall $\rangle$ so to say.

Given the absence of compelling arguments against the family resemblance of propositions, it appears impossible to identify the essence of propositions precisely because propositions do not share essential features. If this analysis is correct, it becomes implausible to claim that every true proposition is made true by some entity, since their similarity is insufficiently robust to support such a general thesis. Thus, the family resemblance concept of proposition leads inexorably to a nonuniform answer to the question of why particular propositions are true.

4 Pluralistic Explanations and Negative Truths

Building upon Wittgenstein's family resemblance concept of proposition, I have advocated a pluralistic view on explaining diverse forms of truth. In this analysis, I shall develop this view more comprehensively and demonstrate how the problem posed by negative truths can be satisfactorily addressed through the pluralistic view.

4.1 The Pluralistic Approach

In contrast to the truthmaker maximalism, which imposes a uniform ontological requirement (the truthmaker) upon every true proposition, the pluralistic view posits that the "truthmaking relation" is not a single metaphysical glue, but a family of explanatory relations determined by the logical role of the proposition in question. Thus, this approach maintains that different truths are true in virtue of different *reasons*. This pluralistic view rests on fundamental pillars.

The First Pillar: The Categorical Divergence of Explanans. The first component recognizes that "making true" implies different activities in different domains. Because propositions function differently—some as descriptions of physical reality, others as rules of symbol manipulation—the *nature* of their explanans must diverge. For formal truths (mathematical/logical): The "truthmaker" is internal to the system. The proposition $\langle 2 + 2 = 4 \rangle$ is true in virtue of the axioms and derivation rules of arithmetic. Here, "in virtue of" designates a relation of deductive entailment, not ontological grounding. To ask for an "entity" that makes it true is to misunderstand the grammar of mathematical proof. For empirical truths: The "truthmaker" is external. The truth depends on how the world stands. However, even within this domain, we must resist the urge to reify every explanation into a distinct entity.

The Second Pillar: The Heterogeneity of Contingent Grounds. The second component addresses the hard cases of contingent truth by acknowledging that even within the propositions about the physical world, truthmakers belong to diverse ontological categories. We do not need a single entity type called a "Fact" to explain all contingent truths; rather, different kinds of truths track different aspects of reality. (1) Positive Existentials (e.g., $\langle \text{There is a cup} \rangle$): These are grounded in Objects. The truth is explained entirely by the existence of the individual object. The proposition does not require a state of affairs (the cup's existing); the cup itself is the sufficient ground. (2) Negative Existentials (e.g., $\langle \text{There are no unicorns} \rangle$) are true in virtue of the absence of a particular object or kind, contingent upon what the negative existential addresses; or alternatively, it is true in virtue of a particular way the world is

not, relative to the subject of the negative existential; (3) Predicative truths (e.g., <The table is yellow>) are made true by the way the world is, is not, was, will be, possibly be, could have been, etc.²⁴ For instance, the proposition <Socrate was a philosopher> is true in virtue of his being a philosopher. The proposition <it is possibly raining tomorrow> is true in virtue of the possibility that it will rain tomorrow. These states of affairs represent the way the world is, is not, was, will be, possibly be and so on.

Pluralism is not merely a collection of ad hoc solutions. It is unified by a single methodological principle: Explanation follows Grammar. By recognizing that truth operates differently in logical, predicative, and existential contexts, we avoid the category mistake of treating <The world does not contain unicorns> as if it had the same type of truthmaker as <Mount Everest exists>. Pluralism thus offers a fine-grain explanation for all truths without populating the universe with unnecessary metaphysical entities.

It is crucial to note that the second pillar represents an implication of the first pillar, serving primarily to deal with specific philosophical challenges. Importantly, the second pillar should not be interpreted as suggesting that truths are necessarily made true by *entities*. Rather, negative existentials and predicative truths are explained by reference to how the world is not, is, was, will be and so on. While metaphysicians may prefer to employ terms like “facts,” “states of affairs,” or even “tropes” and suppose these terms refer to different types of entities, they do not refer to entities beyond individual objects. However, not being entities does not preclude facts from explaining why some truths are true. By allowing individuals and facts to serve as explanans for different truths, we arrive at a pluralistic view.

An objection might be raised against this pluralistic view by appealing to the uniformity of truth itself. It could be argued that even if the *facts* that make propositions true are diverse, the *relation* of truthmaking remains systematic and uniform¹. The objector might point to the deflationary theory of truth—which offers a uniform account (specifically, the schema <p> is true iff p) regardless of content—and argue that if “being true” can be explained uniformly, there is no principled reason why “being made true” cannot be. However, this objection conflates formal uniformity with explanatory uniformity. Deflationism achieves its uniformity precisely because it is ontologically thin—it avoids positing a substantial relation between language and reality. In contrast, the truthmaker maximalism asserts a thick, substantial relation of ontological dependence (necessitation or grounding). Once we move beyond the empty formal schema to the substantial question of *explanation*, the uniformity dissolves. The way a physical object “necessitates” a contingent truth is fundamentally different from the way a proof “necessitates” a mathematical truth; the former is an external ontological grounding, while the latter is an internal grammatical rule. To insist that these distinct explanatory relations are instances of a single, uniform

²⁴ David Lewis and Julian Dodd have argued that the truthmaker theory only needs to admit that truths are grounded in reality. They maintain that reality encompasses both what there is and the way the world is. Under this view, predictions are made true by how the world is rather than by specific entities. See David Lewis (1992, 2001 a); Julian Dodd (2001).

truthmaking relation is to mistake a common linguistic label for a shared metaphysical essence.

4.2 The Pluralistic Approach to Negative Existentials

Truthmaker maximalists have consistently struggled to provide satisfactory truthmakers for negative truths.²⁵ The problem emerges from their view that the world comprises everything that exists, and every truth is true in virtue of what exists. However, a negative truth such as <there are no unicorns> is true not because something exists, but because certain things do not exist—specifically, there are no unicorns. Thus, providing truthmakers for negative truths becomes the most urgent task for maximalists.

Russell²⁶ argued that negative facts should be included in our ontological inventory. However, we need not interpret the phrase “it is not a fact that” as denoting a negative fact. Instead, negation can be interpreted as a truth-functional connective, analogous to conjunction or disjunction. It functions merely as an operator on a sentence.²⁷ C. B. Martin²⁸ proposed that the absence of unicorns could serve as the truthmaker. Yet this appears to be merely a disguised way to abandon maximalism. Armstrong, in contrast, advocated for a totality fact to resolve the problem. A totality fact is a higher-order state of affairs encompassing all and only the first-order states of affairs. While this seems more promising than appealing to absence, as it maintains the maximalist perspective. As one may suggest, the negative existential <there are no unicorns> is logically equivalent to the universal generalization <everything is a non-unicorn>. It might then be argued that this proposition is jointly made true by the *aggregate* of all specific facts about individual objects not instantiating F.

However, this solution is illusory; it conceals the need for a totality fact rather than eliminating it. As Armstrong himself recognized, a mere aggregation of individual facts fails to necessitate the negative truth. Suppose distinct objects ‘a’, ‘b’, and ‘c’, are the only things in the universe, and none are unicorns. The collection of facts <a is not a unicorn>, <b is not a unicorn>, and <c is not a unicorn> does not logically prevent the existence of a fourth object, d, which is a unicorn. For the conjunction of individual facts to serve as a sufficient truthmaker, one must add the distinct fact that <a, b, and c are all the things that exist>. This addition is precisely the “Totality Fact”. Thus, this proposal does not escape the ontological burden of maximalism; it implicitly relies on the very higher-order fact that maximalism is forced to posit.

In what follows, I shall address the problem of negative truths within the pluralistic view framework. Additionally, I plan to examine the early Wittgenstein’s view on correspondence, which I believe offers another solution to the problem, which can be absorbed into the pluralistic view.

In the first section, I argued that truthmaker maximalism stems from an inappropriate extension and the aspiration for unification. If we resist these impulses and

²⁵ Negative propositions include negative predications and negative existentials.

²⁶ See Russell (2010, p.42–7).

²⁷ This objection will be discussed in detail later. Cf. Wittgenstein (2001, 5.44, 5.441).

²⁸ See C. B. Martin (1996).

examine truths and their ordinary explanations, we find that the pluralistic view is more intuitive and reasonable. At their core, negative existentials describe how the world is not. When we assert that there is no x , we simply mean that the world (or a certain region) exists in a way that contains no x .²⁹ Hence, negative existentials are true in virtue of the way the world is not. For example, $\langle$ there are no unicorns $\rangle$ is true in virtue of the fact that the world exists without unicorns. This fact is not an entity existing in reality. Alternatively, one could say it is true in virtue of there being no unicorns, without employing the term “fact.” This solution involves no mysterious entities, and the right side of “in virtue of”—there being no unicorns—remains ontologically neutral.³⁰

Opponents of my view might argue that if facts or states of affairs constitute the way the world is, my perspective implicitly presupposes that we can identify, count, and quantify over facts. If this is indeed the case, then these “ways” exist as entities. Consequently, negative truths and predicative truths³¹ would still depend on some entities (albeit different kinds of entities) to be true.³²

This objection leads to undesirable consequences. There would be numerous odd entities that we undoubtedly do not wish to include in our ontology but which we can nonetheless distinguish, count, and quantify over. For instance, we can distinguish different fictional objects such as fairies, count them, and even quantify over them. However, many philosophers are unwilling to accept such fictional objects as real entities. Therefore, identification, countability, and quantification do not seem to be reliable criteria for determining what counts as an entity.

From a grammatical perspective, nouns and noun phrases create the illusion that they refer to something, which philosophers often interpret as entities. For instance, the phrase “the fact that...” seems to carry ontological weight. However, upon closer examination, we notice significant differences between various facts, exposing how unhelpful it is to ignore these differences and label them uniformly as “entities.”

²⁹ This analysis addresses only contingently negative truths which claim the non-existence of physical objects or kinds. Therefore, the method may not apply to negative truths relevant to mathematics or similar domains.

³⁰ At this juncture, a critic might object that my account overlooks Jonathan Schaffer’s (2010) truthmaker monism, and perhaps even risks collapsing into it. If I concede that $\langle$ There are no unicorns $\rangle$ is true in virtue of the way the world is (or is not), Schaffer would happily conclude that the truthmaker for this proposition is simply the cosmos, namely the world as a whole. Why, the objector might ask, should we prefer my pluralistic rejection of truthmakers over Schaffer’s monism? This objection, however, conflates an ontologically neutral explanation with a substantive ontological commitment. Schaffer’s monism still operates under the orthodox maximalist assumption that truths must be made true by an *entity*. In his case, the single, all-encompassing entity of the cosmos. By contrast, my pluralistic approach firmly resists reifying every explanation into an entity. When I state that the proposition is true in virtue of the world existing without unicorns, I am describing a condition—an absence—rather than pointing to the cosmos as a uniform truthmaking object. To reify ‘the way the world is’ into a universal truthmaker entity is to commit the very category mistake, born of Augustine’s picture of language, that the pluralistic view seeks to dismantle. Therefore, my explanation provides the necessary ground for the truth without carrying the heavy ontological burden of monism.

³¹ Contingently predications are standard propositions which describe the way the world is. Some philosophers think that the corresponding facts are not entities which exist in reality. Instead they are the way reality is.

³² This objection can be seen in (Rodriguez-Pereyra, 2005, p 23–4).

Consider the distinction between the fact that this table is yellow and the fact that $2+2=4$.³³ The former seems to involve a concrete individual and a specific property of that individual,³⁴ while the latter, even if considered an entity, would not be concrete.³⁵ Formalists, for example, argue that numbers are mere symbols or signs devoid of ontological commitments. According to them, the fact that $2+2=4$ is part of a linguistic game. Fictionalists go further, treating mathematics as akin to fiction that refers to fictional objects, which are not even abstract entities.

An objector might argue, as proponents of uniform truthmaking often do, that adopting formalism does not eliminate the need for facts. They might contend that once the formation and transformation rules of a formal system are in place, it becomes a “fact” that certain strings of symbols are provable. Thus, mathematical truths are still “made true” by facts, specifically facts about provability within the system.³⁶

However, this objection inadvertently confirms the family resemblance thesis by stretching the concept of “fact” to the point of ambiguity. When we say “It is a fact that the table is yellow,” we refer to a concrete state of affairs involving a physical object. When we say “It is a fact that $2+2=4$ is provable,” we are referring to an internal grammatical relation between rules and symbols. To treat these two distinct uses of “fact” as identifying the same kind of ontological truthmaker is to be misled by surface grammar. If the “truthmaker” for a mathematical proposition is merely the deductive consequence of syntactical rules, then “truthmaking” in mathematics is an activity of derivation, whereas “truthmaking” in empirical matters is a relation of grounding. By labeling both “facts”, the objector has not unified the theory, but merely concealed the pluralism of explanation under a single, equivocal label.

Weak truthmaker theorists, who restrict the truthmaker theory to contingent truths, might claim that contingent facts are similar enough to be classified as entities. Yet, even this is problematic. Consider the following contingent facts:

- (a) The fact that Everest exists.
- (b) The fact that there are no unicorns.
- (c) The fact that the table is yellow.

Regarding (a), the alleged fact is ontologically parasitic on the individual object. The existence of the fact $\langle \text{Everest exists} \rangle$ tracks perfectly with the existence of the mountain itself. To posit the “Fact” as an entity distinct from the “Object” is to violate Occam’s razor without explanatory gain. The “Fact” here is merely a grammatical shadow cast by the existential statement, not a distinct constituent of reality.

Regarding (b), treating the absence of unicorns as an entity (a negative fact) invites the very ontological monsters maximalism seeks to avoid. It requires us to treat a void or a limit in reality as a substantive “thing” that can be counted and located. As I

³³ Perhaps it is not common to say that $2+2=4$ is a fact. But sometimes, when answering a question of why an arithmetical proposition is true, we do say that it is a fact in order to emphasise its triviality.

³⁴ If we think that a fact is something more than its constituents, then there seems to be a gap in the inference from the concreteness of its constituents to the concreteness of the fact itself.

³⁵ Platonists even like Gödel who believes that mathematical objects are parallel to physical objects would also think that $2+2=4$ is abstract. Cf. Parsons (1995).

³⁶ I thank to one reviewer for bringing about this objection.

argued earlier, negative truths describe how the world is not; reifying this “not-ness” into a “negative entity” is a category mistake born of taking grammar too literally.

Regarding (c), this is often cited by Realists as the primary motivation for admitting Facts. They argue that the Table (particular) and Yellow (universal) could both exist, without the proposition <The table is yellow> being true, as the table is red and yellowness is instantiated in a lemon. Thus, they posit the State of Affairs as the necessary glue or non-mereological composition that binds the particular to the universal. However, this non-mereological nature is precisely what makes facts so metaphysically suspicious. It posits an entity that is more than the sum of its parts, solely to solve a binding problem created by separating the object from its properties in the first place. If we reject the view that properties are independent ingredients needing glue, and instead view them as modes of the object (ways the object is), the need for the “Fact” as a distinct entity vanishes. The truthmaker is simply the yellow table, not a mysterious complex of “Table + Universal + Gluing Relation”.

Thus, classifying these diverse items as “entities” seems artificial and serves only to satisfy truthmaker theorists’ theoretical preferences. These theorists assume that cross-categorical explanatory relations necessitate all explanans (or truthmakers) being entities, often of the same kind, such as facts. However, as I have argued, the term “fact” is merely a linguistic device that does not substantively add to its content; and the phrase “the fact that...” functions differently depending on context.

Therefore, regarding contingent truths, my position agrees with truthmaker theorists in affirming that such truths are grounded in reality. However, I disagree with two claims:

1. That all truths are grounded in reality.
2. That “grounded in reality” entails being made true by some entity.

For example, conceding that there are no unicorns does not imply that this fact is an entity. It merely reflects a particular way the world is not. Hence, “grounded in reality” should mean that truth is explained by some aspect of reality, without overstating this intuition. Moreover, many truths, as I have argued, are entirely unrelated to reality.

At this point, an objector might raise a meta-level challenge regarding the realist principle I have just affirmed—namely, the proposition (P) that our world is such that truth depends on being, and not the other way around. What, they might ask, makes (P) itself true? The objector might attempt to force a dilemma: if (P) is true because of the world, it appears to be a vacuous tautology; but if it is explained merely by the rules of our language game, the framework risks collapsing into radical anti-realism where being depends on language. However, this dilemma mischaracterizes the logical status of (P) within a Wittgensteinian framework. Proposition (P) is not an ordinary empirical proposition; it is a metaphysical principle. Within the empirical language game, (P) functions as a stipulation or a normative rule for description, rather than a description of a contingent fact. To say that (P) is true is to acknowledge it as the foundational rule dictating how the empirical language game is played. Crucially, acknowledging that (P) is a rule of our language game does not entail that physical reality depends on language. I strictly commit to the claim that ordinary empirical propositions are made true contingently by the world, fully preserving realism at the ground level. The rule (P) simply stipulates that empirical truths are to be

evaluated against mind-independent reality. Thus, the rules of the language game govern our explanatory practices without making the external world ontologically dependent on those practices.

4.3 A Variety of Explanans

In fact, we do not necessarily need facts as explanans or truthmakers—whatever they are—to appear on the right side of “in virtue of.” Our explanans can belong to other categories as well, depending on the kinds of truths we are addressing. The most direct objection to the doctrine that all truthmakers are facts (hereafter *factualism*) is that positive existentials are true in virtue of the existence of particular individuals rather than facts. For instance, $\langle$ there are mountains $\rangle$ is true in virtue of the existence of at least one mountain, such as Mount Everest and Mont Blanc. Thus, individuals alone suffice to explain why positive existentials are true.

A *factualist* might appeal to modal considerations to object that the mere object is insufficient. They might argue that “Mont Blanc” refers to a particular chunk of matter or a location, and since that matter could have been distributed as a flat plain (or the location left empty), the mere existence of the matter does not necessitate the truth of $\langle$ There are mountains $\rangle$. Consequently, they insist that the truthmaker must be the fact of that matter instantiating the property of “being a mountain,” rather than the object itself.

However, this objection rests on a confusion between an object and its constituent matter. If the chunk of matter were distributed as a flat plain, the object “Mont Blanc” (the mountain) would simply not exist. The proposition $\langle$ There are mountains $\rangle$ is made true by the existence of mountains, not by the existence of the raw matter that constitutes them. Therefore, if the object Mont Blanc exists, it is necessarily a mountain (consider Kripke’s view on proper name); its existence is sufficient to make the proposition true. To insist that we need the object plus a “fact” that it instantiates mountainhood is to treat the object as a “bare particular” devoid of its own nature. From my pluralistic standpoint, acknowledging the object Mont Blanc is sufficient to explain the truth, rendering the additional “fact” ontologically redundant in this case.

Factualists may still insist that the truthmakers for $\langle$ there are mountains $\rangle$ are facts, such as “the fact that Mount Everest exists” or “the fact that Mont Blanc exists.” While it is legitimate to say, “the fact that Mount Everest exists,” this does not imply that such a fact is more than the existence of the mountain itself. The fact that Mount Everest exists cannot exist independently of Mount Everest’s existence. Therefore, the only reason *factualists* posit such facts as truthmakers is to achieve unification, which is redundant. For this category of truths, individuals are evidently more suitable as truthmakers, supporting my pluralistic view of explanation.

Many truthmaker theorists argue that the truthmaker for $\langle$ the table is yellow $\rangle$ cannot simply be the table, the property of yellowness, or the pairing of the table and yellowness, as none of these candidates would sufficiently make the proposition true. It remains conceivable that these candidates could exist while the proposition itself fails to be true. For example, the table could have been red if it were painted differently. Consequently, *factualists* posit an extra entity, namely a fact, to necessitate the

corresponding proposition. This reasoning explains why realists often prefer facts over alternative options.

To say a table is yellow is to describe the way the table is. Unlike Armstrong's Universals, which are conceived as independent entities that must be 'glued' to particulars by a state of affairs, a 'way' has no existence independent of the object it characterizes. The yellowness of the table is simply how the table is; it is not an extra ingredient added to the table. By viewing properties as particular ways, we dissolve the "binding problem" that motivates Armstrong's theory. If the property is just the object's way of being, there is no ontological gap between the object and the property that requires a Fact or State of Affairs to bridge. Thus, this Wittgensteinian move does not trade one heavy ontology for another; rather, it eliminates the artificial separation of object and property that makes "States of Affairs" seem necessary in the first place. Even if one prefers the language of universals, the demand for a "Fact" over and above the instantiation remains a grammatical superstition. The object being a certain way is all the reality required. Thus, my proposal to treat properties as "particular ways things are" is not intended as a competing metaphysical dogma (such as Class Nominalism), but rather as a metaphysically free observation of grammar.

According to my characterization of properties, a fact, defined as an individual possessing a property or instantiating a relation, is not ontologically distinct from the particular individuals involved. Nevertheless, it is still natural and harmless to acknowledge the existence of facts, provided they are not regarded as entities. Such a perspective supports my pluralistic view of *explanans*, as both individuals and facts serve as *explanans* for different kinds of truths.

4.4 The Solution from Tractatus and the Pluralistic Explanations

It is worth noting that some philosophers address the problem of negative truths in a way that aligns with but is independent of the pluralistic view. They argue that negative truths do not require truthmakers to account for their truth. This idea is suggested in Wittgenstein's *Tractatus*.

Wittgenstein wrote, "If an elementary proposition is true, the state of affairs exists; if an elementary proposition is false, the state of affairs does not exist."³⁷ We can reformulate this claim: if a state of affairs exists, the corresponding proposition is true; if a state of affairs does not exist, the corresponding proposition is false.

Consider this idea in the context of our example. If unicorns exist, then <there are unicorns> is true, and individual unicorns serve as the truthmakers for the proposition. Conversely, if unicorns do not exist, then <there are unicorns> is false, and <there are no unicorns> is trivially true. Thus, there is no need for a distinct truthmaker for negative existentials.

I mentioned that Wittgenstein denied the existence of negative facts, asserting that negative facts are unnecessary to make negative truths true. He viewed negation as analogous to other truth-functions that are not material functions, meaning negation does not denote any object. Wittgenstein argued:

³⁷ Wittgenstein (2001, 4.25). Also see Simons (2005, pp. 255-6).

And if there were an object called ‘ $\sim$ ’, it would follow that ‘ $\sim\sim p$ ’ said something different from what ‘ p ’ said, just because the one proposition would then be about $\sim$ and the other world not.³⁸

This argument presupposes the equivalence of $\sim\sim p$ and p . In ordinary language, there may be subtle differences. For example, the double negation <Your idea isn’t bad> is very different from the proposition <your idea is good>. Nonetheless, their content appears identical. Under this assumption, negation cannot denote any object, as doing so would imply that $\sim\sim p$ and p have different meanings.

In ordinary language, negation can also modify predicates. For instance, consider “Socrates is not alive.” This sentence can be paraphrased as “it is not the case that Socrates is alive.” For sentences involving singular terms, the original and paraphrased versions are equivalent. If the original sentence contains a universal (or existential) quantifier, its paraphrased form will contain an existential (or universal) quantifier. This paraphrase is merely a different way of expressing the same content, highlighting that negation operates as a sentence operator rather than denoting an object.

How, then, can a negative truth be made true? For early Wittgenstein, the solution aligns with the above discussion: a negative truth does not require a truthmaker.

Now consider my solution to the problem. I claim that <there are no unicorns> is true in virtue of there being no unicorns. I further assert that “there are no unicorns” describes the way the world is *not*. However, the fact referred to here is not an entity, and the term “fact” simply signifies something real. In this context, it merely indicates that it is *not real* that there are unicorns. Stated in the language of *The Tractatus*, the claim that it is not real that there are unicorns means that the state of affairs—there are unicorns—does not exist.

Thus, there is no substantial difference between these two solutions when the sole concern is the problem of negative truths. However, I wish to highlight one critical distinction: *The Tractatus* treats states of affairs as entities, whereas, as I argued earlier, facts or states of affairs are not entities.

5 Conclusion

The preceding analysis has demonstrated that the motivations for truthmaker maximalism lack compelling justification. The Truthmaker maximalism overextends itself beyond its appropriate scope. This overextension precisely exemplifies the problem Wittgenstein identified in Augustine’s picture of language. Indeed, truthmaker maximalism essentially recapitulates the Augustine idea at the sentential level, thereby rendering it vulnerable to Wittgensteinian critique.

However, this analysis does not entirely reject the truthmaker theory. At minimum, it offers one approach to answering why a truth is true. The crucial task lies in constraining our ontological impulses within reasonable bounds. Consequently, the question of why a truth is true does not admit a uniform answer—hence the advantages of a pluralistic view. As demonstrated in Sects. 3 and 4, this pluralism manifests in two

³⁸ Wittgenstein (2001, 5.441).

ways: the explanans differs across truth categories, and even within contingent truths, the categories of explanans vary. This plurality stems from the nature of proposition as a family resemblance concept, which undergirds the fundamentally Wittgensteinian character of my critique of truthmaker theory.

The pluralistic framework offers a natural and straightforward explanation for the truth of negative truths—traditionally a significant challenge for truthmaker maximalists. Traditional objections often fixate on grammatical features, which misleadingly seduce the objector into certain ontological commitments. As argued, strictly following grammatical features leads to problematic consequences.

If these arguments prove sound, pursuing the truthmaker maximalism resembles chasing a chimera. The endeavor to identify proper truthmakers for many truths (particularly negative truths) becomes futile. In contrast, pluralism on the truth explanation deserves more attention.

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Declarations

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